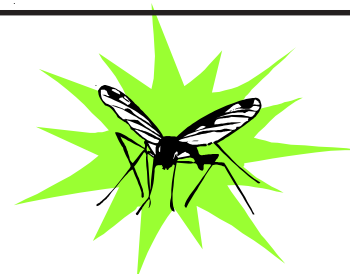




Water Currents

May 2003

April Showers Bring May Mosquitoes??



The summer months are fast approaching. This means outdoor activities and fun, but it also means mosquito season. In recent summers, an added concern is the risk of West Nile Virus.

The West Nile Virus was first found in the United States in the summer of 1999 in New York City. Prior to this, the disease was only found in Africa, Europe and Asia. The summer of 2002 saw mosquitoes test positive for the virus in several areas of Beaver County as well as across Pennsylvania. By summer's end, the virus had made its way across the country to the state of California.

The West Nile Virus is carried by mosquitoes and is spread when the mosquito takes a blood meal from an infected bird and then bites another bird, animal or person. In humans, most cases of the infection are mild, and symptoms resemble the flu. In more serious cases, which are less common, the virus can cause encephalitis, which is an infection of the brain. Those who are most at risk for more serious complications from the virus include persons over age 50. While those with compromised immune systems also have a greater risk, the virus can be contracted by anyone.

One of the best ways to combat the spread of West Nile Virus is to eliminate places where mosquitoes can breed. These areas include any place where a pool of stagnant water can collect. It takes less than a week for mosquitoes to complete the larval stage and become biting adults when they have optimal breeding conditions. Children's wading pools left full over night, wheelbarrows, recycling bins and other containers left outside, discarded tires, and clogged rain gutters all present the opportunity for water to collect. In addition, be sure to protect yourself from a bite by limiting your time outdoors in the evenings, when mosquitoes tend to bite and by using an insect repellent containing 20-30% DEET. Always follow the label instructions and use extra caution when applying repellent to children.

This summer, mosquito surveillance will again be taking place in Beaver County as a means of early detection. Since we already know the virus was present in the county last year, larvaciding – killing of mosquito larvae – will be a focus of this year's program. The larvacide used is a bacteria

that specifically targets mosquito larvae and is harmless to other creatures or the environment. In addition, mosquitoes will be collected at sites around the county through the use of mosquito traps and sampling in mosquito breeding areas. The sampled mosquitoes will then be sent away for testing. Surveillance will be conducted through the Penn State Cooperative Extension from a grant made possible by the Department of Environmental Protection and the continued support of the Beaver County Commissioners.

If you know of a place where mosquitoes are plentiful, please call the extension office at 724-774-3003 so that we may possibly set up a surveillance site in your area. In addition, please visit the WNV website at www.westnile.state.pa.us.

Thirsting for more information?

Visit the Penn State
School of Forest Resources
Water Resources website at

www.sfr.cas.psu.edu/water

HAVE YOU HAD YOUR WATER TESTED LATELY?



While you are thinking about spring cleaning and tidying up the yard around your home, why not think of what is going on under the ground? If you have a well or spring as your home drinking water source, spring is the perfect time to have your water tested for safety. Your water should be tested yearly for bacteria and at least every three years for nitrates, total dissolved solids, and any other local contaminant that has been a problem in the past.

There are several EPA-certified labs in the county that can do these tests for a minimal fee, and a list is available from the extension office. It is definitely worth taking a little extra time to make sure that you and your family are assured a safe drinking water source!

UPCOMING PROGRAMS

Watch future issues of *Water Currents* for information on upcoming workshops this summer:

Home-A-Syst: Learn how to evaluate environmental risks around your home and yard.

Backyard Ponds and Water Gardens: Information about water quality, aquatic plants, basic construction, and ornamental fish.

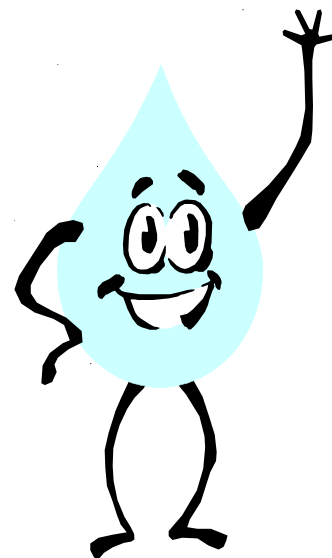
West Nile Virus: What You Need to Know: An in-depth look at the disease and its transmission and prevention.

THINK ABOUT THIS . . .

Aside from being essential to all living things, water is also important in making many of the things we use every day. Here are just a few examples:

- ◆ It takes 17 gallons of water to make one can of pop.
- ◆ It takes 1,800 gallons of water to make one pair of jeans.
- ◆ It takes about 39,000 gallons of water to make one new car.

- From the US EPA
"Teach the Ways of Water" curriculum



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The Pennsylvania State University encourages qualified persons with disabilities to participate in its programs and activities. If you anticipate needing any type of accommodation or have questions about the physical access provided, please contact the Penn State Cooperative Extension of Beaver County at 724-774-3003 in advance of your participation or visit.

Sincerely,

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